LEADERSHIP QUARTER • WHITE PAPER

Sharper Leaders

An Evidence-Based Review of the LQ8 Leadership Framework

This is a true full-page redesign edition. The layout now uses fixed A4 canvases so each page fills the sheet edge-to-edge with branded visual treatment and no centered document column.

Author: Jason Hunt • September 2025 source • Full-page redesign v3 (March 2026)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Eight competencies, one integrated system

The LQ8 model organises leadership capability into four connected quadrants. The evidence supports each dimension and also confirms that system-level interaction effects drive the strongest outcomes.

Inner Compass

Emotional Intelligence + Ethical Leadership establish trust, judgement discipline, and credibility.

Thinking in Motion

Strategic Thinking + Adaptability improve direction and recalibration under uncertainty.

Relating to Others

Collaboration + Stakeholder Influence align execution across functions and interests.

Progress & Growth

Execution & Accountability + Learning Agility sustain delivery and long-term capability lift.

QUADRANT 1 • INNER COMPASS

Emotional Intelligence and Ethical Leadership

Emotional Intelligence

Linked to trust, conflict quality, engagement, and composure under pressure. Most effective as a force multiplier across other capabilities.

Ethical Leadership

Associated with fairness perceptions, commitment, and lower misconduct risk. Integrity is a direct performance variable in leadership systems.

- Trust and psychological safety are foundational enablers, not soft add-ons.
- Measurement should combine self-report with multi-rater evidence.
- Capability gaps here often explain downstream delivery failures.

QUADRANT 2 • THINKING IN MOTION

Strategic Thinking and Adaptability

Strategic Thinking

Supports long-horizon prioritisation and better trade-off management in complex operating conditions.

Adaptability

Critical for change response and a common derailment point when absent, even among technically strong leaders.

- Strategy without adaptability can become rigidity.
- Adaptability without strategic intent can become reactive drift.
- High-performing leaders maintain purpose while flexing methods.

QUADRANT 3 • RELATING TO OTHERS

Collaboration and Stakeholder Influence

Collaboration

Increases implementation reliability by improving shared ownership, communication flow, and cross-functional trust.

Stakeholder Influence

Builds coalition momentum through credibility, alignment, and pragmatic negotiation across competing interests.

- Influence is strongest when anchored in ethical and relational credibility.
- High-quality collaboration reduces friction and decision latency.

QUADRANT 4 • PROGRESS & GROWTH

Execution, Accountability, and Learning Agility

Execution & Accountability

Turns intent into results through clear goals, ownership discipline, and structured follow-through.

Learning Agility

Acts as a meta-competency that accelerates adaptation and performance across every other domain.

- Constructive accountability outperforms punitive control cultures.
- Learning-agile leaders outperform in novel and ambiguous contexts.

SYNTHESIS AND APPLICATION

Using LQ8 as an operating model

The review indicates that LQ8 delivers strongest value when used systemically for assessment, succession, and development, rather than as isolated training modules.

- Diagnose patterns across competencies, not single scores.
- Address root causes in foundational domains before treating symptoms.
- Embed stretch assignments, review loops, and behavioural feedback cycles.
- Track outcomes against engagement, execution quality, retention, and performance.

Conclusion: LQ8 is a practical, evidence-led architecture for leadership quality in high-change, high-stakes operating environments.

REFERENCES (CONDENSED)

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